

Salary Range Map — Java Developers in India

Java Interview Prep — 2026 Edition · Learn & Excel

Use this AFTER the offer arrives. Open it BEFORE you say yes. Every number here comes from public salary sources (Glassdoor, AmbitionBox, Levels.fyi India) cross-referenced with hiring-manager and recruiter conversations across Indian product, service, GCC, and startup companies. Updated 2026.

How to read this

- **Numbers are total CTC** (cost-to-company) in lakhs per annum (LPA), unless stated otherwise
 - **Ranges shown are typical** — outliers exist on both sides (you can earn less than the bottom of the range; top performers blow past the top)
 - **Variable / bonus / ESOPs** treated separately from fixed pay
 - All numbers below assume **Bengaluru / Hyderabad / Pune / NCR** metro markets. Tier-2 cities trim 15-25% off most ranges.
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Service MNC

The big consulting/services companies — TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, Cognizant, HCL, Tech Mahindra, Capgemini.

Experience	Fixed CTC (LPA)	Variable / bonus	What pushes you to top of range
0-1 yr (Fresher)	3.5 – 5.5	0 – 5%	College tier (IIT / NIT / BITS = top of range); coding round score; pre-placement offer
1-3 yr	5 – 9	5 – 10%	Cleared internal tech assessment; visible deliverable; small project leadership
3-5 yr	9 – 18	10 – 15%	Module lead for 5+ engineers; client-facing role; onsite eligibility
5-8 yr	16 – 28	12 – 18%	Architect designation; client SOW signed off; pre-sales contribution
8-12 yr	25 – 45	15 – 25%	Project Manager / Tech Architect roles; P&L responsibility for a small unit
12+ yr	40 – 70 +	18 – 30%	Account-level ownership; revenue responsibility; senior-architect-level certifications (AWS Solutions, GCP Cloud Architect, etc.)

Promotion cycle: typically 18-24 months. Annual hike: 5-10% for "Meets Expectations," 12-18% for "Exceeds Expectations." A switch externally typically beats 2 years of internal hikes combined.

What service MNCs UNDER-pay for: backend depth, system-design knowledge, modern frameworks (Spring Boot 3, virtual threads, K8s). They'll pay you for "years of experience" not "depth of skill."

Indian Product Companies

Razorpay, Cred, Swiggy, Zomato, Zerodha, Groww, Meesho, PhonePe, Postman, BrowserStack, Freshworks, Chargebee, Apna, Innovaccer.

Experience	Fixed CTC (LPA)	Variable / ESOPs	What pushes you to top of range
0-1 yr (Fresher)	12 – 25	0 – 5% bonus	College tier + competitive programming score; FAANG-style interview prep showing
1-3 yr	18 – 35	10 – 20% bonus, ESOPs ~50K-3L value	Production ownership at past role; OSS contributions; specific stack match
3-5 yr	30 – 55	15 – 25% bonus, ESOPs ~3L-10L value	Mid-level system design (you've built ONE complete service end-to-end); on-call experience
5-8 yr	45 – 80	20 – 30% bonus, ESOPs ~10L-30L value	Senior IC who creates leverage for the team; design reviews accepted; cross-team mentorship
8-12 yr	65 – 120	25 – 40% bonus, ESOPs ~30L-80L value	Staff / Principal IC track; org-wide impact; tech-strategy contributions
12+ yr	100 – 200 +	30 – 50% bonus, ESOPs vary widely (₹1Cr+ at later-stage cos)	Architect role with platform-wide influence; advisor signal; ex-founder credibility

ESOPs caveat: pre-IPO ESOPs at private companies have illiquid value — treat liquidation events (acquisitions, IPOs) as uncertain. Discount to 20-50% of "paper value" for planning. Post-IPO companies (Zomato, Paytm) have liquid equity but stock price risk.

Promotion cycle: 12-18 months at most product cos. Annual hike: 10-15% baseline, 18-25% for high performers. Internal hikes typically match external switches if you're performing.

What product cos OVER-pay for vs service MNCs: actual system-design skill, on-call ownership, production debugging experience, scaling expertise. A 3-year product-co engineer often out-earns a 6-year service-MNC engineer.

GCC / Global Capability Centres

In-house engineering offices of US/EU multinationals in India. Two broad sub-types: **Financial-services GCCs** (JP Morgan, Wells Fargo, Goldman Sachs, Morgan Stanley, Citi, American Express) — bands close to those below. **Big Tech India captives** (Apple India, Microsoft India, Amazon India, Adobe India, Cisco, Salesforce India, Atlassian India, LinkedIn India, Broadcom-VMware, Uber India) — often 30-50%

above the bands below at senior levels, especially when RSUs are factored in. Walmart Labs and Target sit in between.

Experience	Fixed CTC (LPA)	Variable / RSU	What pushes you to top of range
0-1 yr (Fresher)	18 – 35	5 – 10% bonus, possibly RSU vesting starts	Strong CS fundamentals; competitive programming; specific tech stack
1-3 yr	25 – 50	10 – 15% bonus, RSU ~3-15L/yr	High-impact IC; cross-functional skill; cloud certifications
3-5 yr	40 – 75	15 – 20% bonus, RSU ~10-30L/yr	Senior IC with feature ownership; design- leadership; mentor role
5-8 yr	60 – 110	18 – 25% bonus, RSU ~20-60L/yr	Staff engineer track; cross-team impact; principal-track signals
8-12 yr	90 – 180	25 – 35% bonus, RSU ~50L-1.5Cr/yr	Principal / Distinguished engineer; technical-track lead
12+ yr	150 – 350 +	30 – 45% bonus, RSU varies	Distinguished engineer; technical fellow track; very few seats

RSU specifics: most US-parented GCCs grant RSUs vesting over 4 years (typical cliff: 1 year, then quarterly/monthly). Liquid as long as the company is publicly traded. Stock price moves directly affect compensation.

Promotion cycle: 12-24 months. GCCs tend to have more rigorous promotion criteria than Indian product cos but compensate well at higher levels.

What GCCs especially pay for: distributed systems experience, large-scale operations, on-call discipline, English-language communication, cross-time-zone collaboration.

Startup (Early Stage)

Seed / pre-Series A / Series A: ~5-50 people total, typically 2-15 engineers, founders still very involved.

Experience	Fixed CTC (LPA)	ESOPs (% equity)	What pushes you to top of range
0-2 yr	8 – 20	0.05 – 0.3%	Founding-engineer signal; willingness to do everything; product taste
2-5 yr	18 – 40	0.2 – 1.0%	Senior IC who's seen production scale; backend + frontend versatility
5-8 yr	30 – 70	0.5 – 2.0%	Tech lead who can manage 3-5 engineers + recruit; system design at scale
8+ yr	50 – 120 +	0.5 – 3.0% (CTO-track)	Founding CTO / VP Engineering signals; previous startup exit; investor network

Note: Early-stage equity has lottery-ticket distribution — most goes to zero, a small fraction becomes meaningful, very few become life-changing. Don't take below-market cash assuming equity will compensate.

Series B+ startup (50-300 people, post-product-market-fit): closer to product-co bands above, with slightly more ESOPs and slightly less cash. Examples: Chargebee, Apna, Postman, Innovaccer.

Negotiation thresholds

How to think about what to push for, by your situation:

Situation	Reasonable ask above your offered fixed CTC
First offer at first job	+5-10% (you have minimal leverage)
Second offer after 1-2 yr	+15-25% (you've established work signal)
Job switch with competing offer	+20-35% (the competing offer is your leverage)
Switch from service MNC to product co	+40-80% (this is the famous "service-to-product jump")
Switch from product co to GCC	+20-40% (depending on RSU value)
Switch from one product co to another	+25-45% if hot specialization (Razorpay/Cred for fintech, Swiggy for e-comm)
Switch from startup to bigco	varies — startups often pay below market, so jumps are bigger
Internal raise without external offer	+10-15% in good years, less in down markets
Internal raise with external offer	+20-35%, plus refresh on equity if applicable

The retention-counter trap: if you give notice and your current employer matches the external offer, the recruiter rule-of-thumb is most people who accept a counter-offer leave within 12 months anyway — and their next move is from a weaker negotiating position. Default move: politely decline counters unless something material has changed beyond money.

Year-over-year trend (2024 → 2026)

Coarse trends across the Indian Java/backend market:

Segment	2024 → 2026 change	Drivers
Service MNC freshers	Slight cut (-5 to -10%)	Hiring slowdown; replacing higher-cost juniors with AI tooling at the bottom of the ladder
Service MNC senior	Flat to +5%	Demand persists for client-facing roles
Product company mid-level	+10 to +20%	War for backend talent post-AI-tooling boom
Product company senior	+15 to +30%	Companies paying up for system-design-capable seniors
GCC any level	+5 to +15%	Steady, dollar-pegged compensation gives upside
Startup seed/Series A	Flat (cash)	Funding crunch ongoing
Startup Series B+	+10 to +20%	Companies needing to retain talent through extended exits

Specialist premium in 2026 — these specific skills add 15-30% on top of base CTC: - Distributed systems design (proven at scale) - Kubernetes / EKS / GKE production operations - AI infrastructure (model serving, RAG, vector DBs) - Performance engineering (JVM tuning, GC, low-latency) - Spring Boot 3 + reactive (Project Reactor, WebFlux) - Virtual threads + structured concurrency adoption experience

How to verify these ranges yourself

Don't trust this PDF alone. Cross-check against your own situation using:

- **AmbitionBox** — most data points from Indian employees, but biased toward service MNC and bigco
- **Glassdoor** — international, often outdated, but useful for ranges
- **Levels.fyi (India)** — best for product co + GCC, especially equity components
- **Salary discussions on r/developersIndia** — recent, real, often very specific by company
- **Recruiter inMails on LinkedIn** — most recruiters will tell you the range if you ask "what's the band for this role?" before agreeing to interview
- **Friends at the target company** — single best signal; if you have ANY connection, ask

When you have an offer in hand, run it through ALL 3 sources before deciding. A 10-minute cross-check is usually enough to tell whether you're in the lower, middle, or upper third of your band — and gives you concrete numbers to anchor your pushback if you're below market.

What to do RIGHT NOW with this map

- **Got an offer:** find your row above. Ask: am I in the lower, middle, or upper third? If lower, you have ammunition to push.
- **Preparing for interviews:** target the band you're aiming for. If you want product-co money, your prep needs to match product-co question depth (files 04, 05, 06 in this pack).
- **No active offer:** bookmark this. Re-read in 6 months. The market shifts; we update this pack every 6 months.

You're worth what someone agrees to pay you. This map exists so you walk into that conversation prepared.

— The Learn & Excel team